



Science and superstition

The sun and moon are important astrological signs

"IT IS THE STARS, the stars above that govern our conditions," says the Earl of Kent in *King Lear*. In Shakespeare's time, many people believed in astrology – the idea that heavenly bodies could control or influence life on Earth. Even Queen Elizabeth consulted an astrologer, the brilliant Dr. John Dee. And sailors used the sun and the stars to find their way at sea. Improvements in methods of navigation, such as the back-staff, meant that, by the 16th century, English ships were sailing into all of the world's oceans.

MIRROR, MIRROR

Dr. John Dee (1527–1608) owned this "srying mirror," which he said had been given to him by an angel. It was actually made by the Aztec people of Mexico, but no one knows how the doctor came to have it. Dee would gaze into the mirror, hoping to see spirits or visions of the future.



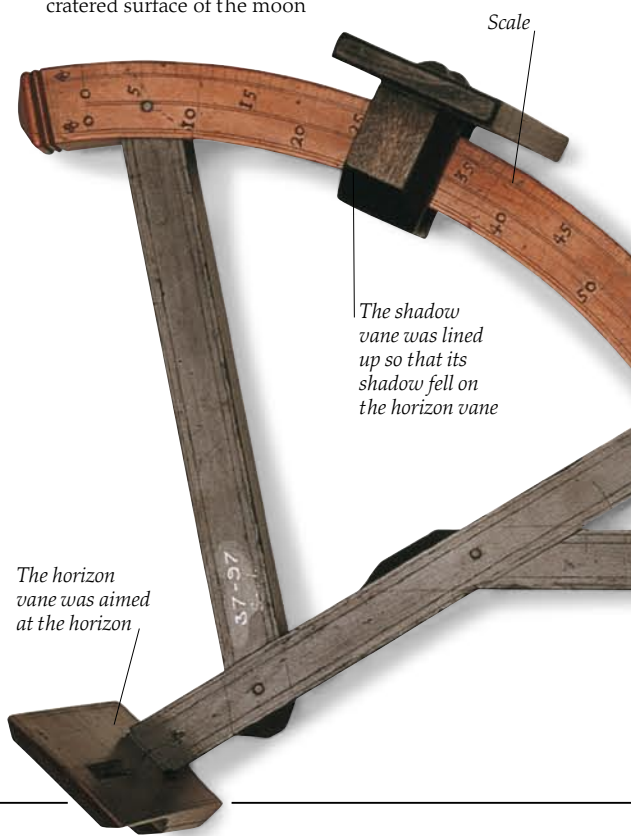
Engraving of Dr. John Dee making calculations with a globe and compass



Galileo's 1610 book *The Starry Messenger*, showing the scientist's drawings of the cratered surface of the moon

STAR GAZING

In 1609, the Italian scientist Galileo Galilei (1564–1642) built a telescope and looked at the night sky through it. He published his discoveries in his book *The Starry Messenger*. Galileo was amazed to see thousands of stars, which no one had seen before. He also discovered four moons orbiting Jupiter, and studied craters and mountains on the surface of Earth's moon.



The horizon vane was aimed at the horizon